



Beyond the label: Students' view of placement and replacement in between-class ability grouping

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ABSTRACT

Ability grouping is a common practice aimed at improving learning outcomes by targeting students' abilities, yet research on students' perspectives is limited. This study explores the views of 20 lower secondary school students on grouping mechanisms, preferred approaches, and movement between groups. The findings highlight students' ability to identify system limitations and the need for their active involvement. Incorporating student perspectives can inform teaching strategies and teacher education programs by offering valuable insights into the dynamics of grouping and its impact on learning experiences.

1. Introduction

Ability grouping has been widely used to improve the quality and effectiveness of teaching and learning. This approach assumes that, by targeting students' abilities, their learning will be more efficient than learning in mixed-ability groups or classes. Nevertheless, empirical evidence shows that this theoretical assumption works especially for students in high-ability groups: they acquire better knowledge and skills than their classmates in other groups (e.g. [Wilkinson & Penney, 2014](#)). However, students from low-ability groups performed worse than they would in mixed-ability classes (e.g. [Deunk et al., 2018](#)).

Ability grouping has the potential to exacerbate existing educational inequalities because social background has an impact on placing students into ability groups – students from minority ethnic groups are over-represented in lower sets ([Connolly et al., 2019](#)), and students with academically educated parents are over-represented in high-ability sets (e.g. [Feniger, Bar-Haim & Blank, 2021](#); [Kantasalmi & Kupiainen, 2021](#)). Therefore, this practice frequently faces criticism, with proponents advocating teaching methods that involve mixed-ability classes as a more suitable and equitable approach ([Zapfe & Gross, 2021](#)). This recommendation underscores the belief that a diverse classroom setting offers greater potential to support all students in their learning journey, regardless of their initial academic prowess, thereby fostering a more inclusive educational environment ([Tomlinson, 2015](#)). However, different forms of ability grouping have different effects. A second-order meta-analysis showed that all students benefited from within-class grouping, cross-grade subject grouping, and special grouping for the

gifted ([Steenbergen-Hu, Makel & Olszewski-Kubilius, 2016](#)). The OECD's PISA 2018 data ([OECD, 2019](#)) shows that the negative differences in reading scores are larger when schools group students by ability into different classes for all subjects (i.e. streaming), as opposed to some subjects (i.e. setting). Therefore, it is evident that different forms of ability grouping may be controversial in different ways from the point of view of equal educational opportunities.

In their summary article, [Francis et al. \(2017a\)](#) presented a potential explanation for the adverse effects of group instruction on lower-achieving students. This is mainly due to the incorrect placement of the pupil in a group, low permeability between groups, and teaching based on expectations and not on actual performance, but also on the pupil's perception of teaching in groups and experiences from it, and their influence on the pupil's identity. Together, these factors create a self-fulfilling prophecy.

Even though processes of sorting and (re)grouping in general have been extensively studied (e.g. [Muijs & Dunne, 2010](#); [Connolly et al., 2019](#); [Neumann, 2019](#); [Bradbury et al., 2021](#)), the body of research on students' perceptions of the criteria for grouping students, the tools for (re)grouping, and the permeability of groups is limited. Therefore, in our study, we focused on the students' perspectives. We consider targeting the perspective of students to be important because their viewpoint is crucial for creating a vivid picture of the processes of placement and (re) placement. Therefore, in our study, we present the results from a Czech lower secondary school that applies setting in the sixth grade in English as a Foreign Language (EFL) and mathematics. We describe how the students perceive the criteria and the process of sorting, which leads

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them to consider changing their current group, what their expectations are, and how they perceive the conditions they must meet to change their group.

Understanding students' perspectives on placement and replacement in between-class ability grouping is crucial for teachers, as it sheds light on how these practices impact learners' motivation, engagement, and academic development. Teachers play a vital role in shaping classroom dynamics and instructional strategies, and by considering students' views, they can make informed decisions that enhance learning outcomes and promote equity. Additionally, integrating student feedback into teacher education programs can equip future educators with a deeper awareness of how ability grouping affects different learners, allowing them to design more inclusive and responsive teaching practices.

1.1. Literature review

In this paper, we focus on between-class ability grouping, known as "setting" (Taylor et al., 2020), a particular form of ability grouping in which students within one school are grouped only for selected subjects (typically mathematics, the native language, and foreign languages). Research from countries where ability grouping is used extensively has provided much evidence that ability grouping does not bring much benefit – the composition of groups reflects the social composition of pupils (Archer et al., 2018) and usually benefits pupils from higher-performing groups and harms pupils from groups with lower performance (e.g. OECD, 2016). Pupils from groups with lower performance are offered a reduced curriculum, whereas some pupils from groups with higher performance do not sufficiently understand the curriculum offered to them (Boaler, 2000). Moreover, ability grouping affects collaborative problem-solving patterns (An & Zhang, 2024). Heterogeneous groups exhibit more socially oriented communication and tend to raise questions related to learning tasks. In addition to that, the groups in the study of An and Zhang (2024) also differed in their negotiation approaches; deep negotiation was less likely in the homogeneous groups because of the similarity in ability levels.

Ability grouping is a common practice, particularly at the secondary school level in countries such as the UK (Taylor et al., 2020), the USA (Deunk et al., 2018), and Australia (Johnston & Taylor, 2023). While formal setting or streaming is less prevalent in primary schools, forms of within-class grouping based on ability are increasingly being adopted. For instance, Bradbury and al. (2021) found that ability grouping—including within-class and across-class groups—was widely used as a response to external accountability pressures, particularly around standardized assessments (e.g., SATs). Additionally, McGillicuddy (2021) showed that ability grouping created distinct social and academic hierarchies. Teachers, through their grouping practices, exerted an 'invisible hand' that shaped children's peer networks, often reinforcing existing social divisions. Children placed in higher ability groups, who were predominantly from majority ethnic backgrounds, enjoyed higher social status and greater inclusion among peers. In contrast, those in lower ability groups, often from minority ethnic backgrounds, experienced marginalization, exclusion, and a higher incidence of bullying.

Advocates of ability grouping highlight its capacity to allow teachers to tailor instruction to the specific needs of students, thus fostering a more targeted and challenging curriculum (e.g. Rogers, 2007; Preckel et al., 2019). This could be particularly advantageous for high-achieving students who thrive in specialized learning environments (Dare & Nowicki, 2019). By organizing students into more homogeneous groups, educators can align their teaching methods better with students' perceived skill levels. This teaching and learning efficiency enhances the overall learning experience for both teachers and students. Another significant driver of support for ability grouping is parental demand: some parents believe that this practice provides their children with a more challenging and stimulating learning environment and creates an

education tailored to their children's individual needs. Grouping is also believed to enhance students' performance on standardized tests, which is a motivation for schools.

In Europe, Furcsa (2014) demonstrated that grouping has a negative impact on students in low-performance groups; their aspirations remain low and motivation gradually declines. These groups can also serve as a segregation tool; in Hungary, even Roma students whose performance does not match that of the group are placed in them. In the same study, low-performance groups concentrate on students with specific educational needs who often exhibit disciplinary issues. Teaching quality in these groups was relatively low and associated with low expectations. Classroom observations revealed that the content and teaching processes frequently mismatched students' needs. An ethnographic study from Sweden also showed that grouping creates a system in which students have access to various types of knowledge (Gustafsson, 2018). This highlights that implementing this model absolves the school of responsibility for educational outcomes, transferring that responsibility to students.

Students' preferences for grouping practices and their satisfaction with their ability group placement were explored by Hallam and Ireson (2006; 2007). Quantitative studies found that students preferred setting to mixed-ability classes (Hallam & Ireson, 2006). At the same time, 20 %–30 % of students wanted to change their set, mostly upwards (Hallam & Ireson, 2007). Relatively recently, Archer et al. (2018) examined the perceived legitimacy of setting and found out that students from the lowest sets were more likely to have a negative attitude towards setting, while students from the highest sets described ability grouping as "natural" and "deserved". Setting was interpreted as a mechanism of social reproduction that reflects the interests of the privileged and is designed to racialize and maintain inequalities. Neumann (2019) documented how an English secondary school shifted from mixed-ability teaching to an attainment-based grouping structure and how this data-driven practice created an insecure environment of competition for the students.

In summary, while ability grouping may offer certain benefits, such as tailored instruction and improved academic performance for some students, its drawbacks, including exacerbating inequality and affecting students' psychological well-being, warrant careful consideration.

1.2. Context

In the Czech Republic, educational practices such as tracking and within-class grouping are common in secondary education. However, between-class ability grouping is relatively rare. The Czech Republic is among the countries with a strong correlation between a family's socioeconomic status and a child's academic performance (OECD, 2023). One contributing factor is the early tracking that occurs in lower secondary education, which is targeted for reduction according to the main educational policy document, Strategy 2030+ (Fryč et al., 2020). In response to the limited availability of places in early tracks, various forms of ability grouping, such as streaming and setting, are prevailing within compulsory education. These practices, however, are not reflected in official statistics. Schools primarily adopt these forms to make education more appealing, although some also consider the potentially lower impact of streaming and setting on equal opportunities.

Within-class ability grouping is especially prevalent in foreign language teaching, where students are often divided into "more advanced" and "less advanced" groups. High-ability groups offer enhanced learning opportunities; language-related stays abroad were exclusively organized for such groups in 20 % of schools, as reported by the Czech School Inspectorate (CSI, 2018). Teachers generally express positive attitudes toward ability grouping, citing smaller group sizes and ability grouping as the third most requested measure for the development of foreign language literacy (ibid). However, within-class ability grouping is less common in subjects other than foreign languages.

Some schools adopt a hybrid approach, combining ability-grouped

and heterogeneous classes, especially for foreign languages, mathematics, and mother tongue (e.g. students have two classes per week in ability groups and another two or three classes in heterogeneous classes). Navrátilová (2019) examined student participation in both types of classes at the lower secondary level. The high-ability group reported greater activity in ability-grouped classes, primarily as a result of the reduced class size. However, participation dynamics varied between the two groups, with high-ability students being more active in ability-grouped classes, especially in situations in which they were sure of the correct answer, in order to avoid potential mockery from their groupmates. The climate in the high-ability groups was competitive, with students vying to provide the correct answer first. In contrast, students from the low-ability groups were not afraid to take risks, knowing that they would not be penalized by the teacher or their classmates for an incorrect answer.

The opportunities for between-class ability grouping have been facilitated by the new funding system introduced in 2020, allowing funding for two teachers per class for a limited number of lessons. Schools can use this subsidy for tandem teaching, in which two teachers are present synchronously, or for ability grouping with groups in different classrooms. Nevertheless, there is limited information on the between-class grouping processes, including sorting and resorting, and students' perceptions of teaching and learning in such groups. Given the absence of research on the implementation of between-class ability grouping in the Czech Republic and the limited resources on students' perceptions of between-ability practices, this study aims to address these gaps. Since between-class ability grouping was introduced as an alternative to tracking in the Czech Republic, we were particularly interested in evaluating whether it truly offers a better solution and whether the challenges associated with tracking persist within the context of between-class ability grouping.

2. Methodology

2.1. Research questions and design

To enhance and broaden our understanding of students' perceptions of ability grouping, the purpose of our investigation was to address the following research questions: (1) How do students perceive the criteria for grouping? (2) What factors lead students to consider changing their groups? (3) How do students perceive the conditions they must meet to change their groups?

To answer the research questions, a qualitative, sociologically-oriented case study approach was employed (Merriam, 1998). We conducted a study focusing on four schools that employed ability grouping in classes providing lower secondary education. The schools were not selected in advance but were included gradually on the basis of the results of the analysis of continuously obtained data (Merriam, 1998). In the present study, we present the results of a case study examining the Countryside School.

2.2. Participants

To include a school in the research, a purposive sampling method was chosen (Merriam, 1998). This approach assumes that the goal of the research is to gain insight into the problem, which requires selecting cases that are information-rich and allow for such insight. The following criteria were used:

1. A public school offering both primary and lower secondary education.
2. The school must have at least two classes in each grade of lower secondary education.
3. Ability grouping is used for specific subjects (e.g. mathematics, English as a second language), and this grouping is not limited to foreign language instruction.

From the schools that met the above criteria, individual schools were selected using theoretical sampling. In this approach, schools are not all selected in advance but are included gradually based on the results of the analysis of data collected throughout the research process. The research begins with the selection of one relevant case, and the choice of subsequent cases arises from the emerging theory based on data analysis (Merriam, 1998: 63).

Participants were students at the first chosen school. The school is located in a town with a population of several thousand people with good transport to a larger city nearby. With approximately 800 pupils in two buildings, it is the only school in town and the school's catchment area includes several nearby villages.

Between-class ability grouping was introduced for the first time in the sixth grade during the 2021/22 school year. After 14 years of using the setting approach, school leaders decided to adopt this new approach to make the school more appealing to students and their parents while also promoting a more equitable educational environment. In this grade, there were four classes, with students from each pair of classes grouped into three performance levels for mathematics and four for English. The teachers in these subjects taught two groups with a given performance, each formed from a different pair of classes. The only informants regarding the research questions were sixth-grade students who had experience with teaching in cross-class groups. The school management was asked to select for interviews two to three pupils from each performance group who had good relations with each other and pupils who had experience with transferring between groups. The interviews were conducted in eight groups (three in mathematics and five in English), and a total of 20 pupils in the age of 12–14 participated, 14 girls and 6 boys. Each interview group comprised 2–3 students. We initially aimed to conduct interviews with three students per group; however, in some instances, selected students were absent on the day of the interviews. In our request to school management, we specifically asked that at least one student in each interview group have experience with changing groups. This criterion was important to ensure that the discussions included first-hand insights into the process and perception of group transitions. The group size was deliberately chosen to balance two key considerations: to ensure that students did not feel isolated or uncomfortable in a one-on-one setting, and to provide ample opportunity for each participant to express their thoughts and experiences.

2.3. Data collection and analysis

The data comprised eight semi-structured interviews with 20 students. An interview outline was initially developed for the first case study and subsequently refined on the basis of practical experience. The interviews were conducted on the school premises. Throughout the interviews, we explored various aspects, including the group assignment process, students' perspectives and satisfaction regarding group assignments, features attributed to specific groups by students, teaching and learning dynamics within these groups, disparities in the curriculum and assessment between groups, students' satisfaction with their teaching and learning experiences, and the procedure for group changes.

The interviews were recorded on a dictaphone and later transcribed. The data analysis followed an iterative process using open coding (Corbin & Strauss, 2008; Charmaz 2006) in the MaxQDA software.

In the first phase, initial codes were assigned to meaningful segments of the text based on their content. These codes emerged inductively from the data, with constant comparison applied to ensure consistency. To enhance reliability, at least two researchers independently coded a subset of the transcripts and then discussed discrepancies to refine the coding scheme.

In the second cycle, the already-established categories were further refined and elevated to a higher level of abstraction, ensuring alignment with the research focus. Throughout the recoding and categorization process, the categories were iteratively revised, expanded, or collapsed as necessary. This process was guided by regular team discussions,

where emerging insights were critically evaluated. Additionally, the categories were supported with illustrative data extracts to ensure transparency and maintain a close connection between empirical findings and theoretical interpretation (e.g., Maxwell, 2013).

The principles of confidentiality (Flick, 2004) were observed as part of the research investigation. All students were assured of privacy, i.e. their names and the names of individual schools were anonymized. Additionally, data that could identify the research participants was modified in the interviews.

3. Results

3.1. Placement – a single performance test is not enough

Students think that the performance measured by the test they took at the end of the previous school year (in the fifth grade) was the main sorting criterion: *“We took the placement tests simply to know how we were doing. They then sorted us accordingly,”* said Lina (middle-ability group, mathematics). In principle, the students who were interviewed agreed with their placement according to the test results. Tom (high-ability group in mathematics) thought: *“I just think that it is a good way [of grouping] to do the sorting tests ...some [students] are excellent at math, and some are not so excellent...and those who are excellent got bored in a [mixed-ability] class...”*

In English, the students from all sets who were interviewed said that the placement test was easy, and they did not think that the sorting was significantly burdensome. One of the reasons why students perceive placement tests as easy may be their repetitive nature: students undergo identical tests in English again in the middle of the school year, when student performance is re-evaluated. The perceived ease might reflect the fact that students are familiar with the test since they took the same test several months previously. Despite the reflected low level of difficulty, the placement tests did not have as good results as expected for some students – they thought that the results did not reflect their own perceptions of their performance.

Students attributed their unsatisfactory results to the stress experienced during the test. Even students who did not feel stressed commented on the possibility of incorrect classification as a result of a failed test. Fred (middle-ability group, ESL) stated: *“Sometimes, for example, someone just sleeps badly, I’m not saying that everyone... they just somehow mess up and then, you know, are sorted needlessly into a worse group, while they’re doing well.”* Some students spoke about the failed test from personal experience, for example, Dina (low-ability group, mathematics): *“I was really stressed, so I think if I hadn’t been so stressed, I might have got into the better group.”* As a result of the failed test, some students were sorted into the lower-ability set, although they perceived their performance as being sufficient for the higher-ability set.

At the same time, the opposite situation can occur, with some students being lucky enough to get into the higher-ability set after the placement test, although their general performance matches the lower-ability set. Students, however, commented more often on the first variant, that is, on failing the test because of stress and being put into the lower-ability set. Some reported that they were stressed about any testing; however, placement tests stressed them more than regular testing because the placement tests are high-stakes tests. Even though there is a possibility of changing groups, students perceived the placement tests as binding; they probably did not think about changing groups at the time when they took the tests.

For the reasons mentioned above, some students do not consider sorting into sets according to the results of a single test to be a reliable decision. They believed that the test may not work for those who are stressed. This might be especially true for students at the edge of the performance span. Some students were able to propose additional sorting criteria that could strengthen the reliability of the sorting. Students suggested the teacher’s judgement as one way to triangulate the placement tests: *“In my opinion, in general it would be better if the teacher*

himself considered whether it [the performance] is better or not. At least for mathematics,” Lucy (middle ability group, mathematics). A second option for strengthening the reliability of the placement tests was a trial. *“We would be in that group for, I don’t know, two weeks and then they would decide whether we belong there or not,”* explained Vanessa (middle ability group, mathematics).

By proposing alternative approaches to placement, the students demonstrated a relatively significant agency: the motivation and ability to decide, act, and transform their environment in interaction with the social context (Vaughn, 2020). Their proposals are quite relevant; however, the school has not established mechanisms for communication about systemic changes between teachers, school management, and students, so the transfer of this “expert” opinion from students to teachers and management remains a matter of chance. Moreover, suggestions for ways to improve the situation more often come from students who are dissatisfied with the current situation. There are usually relatively few such students, so it may be difficult for them to push the proposed innovations.

3.2. Triggers for set change – boredom and experiences from a different set

Even though students agreed in principle with setting as a way of organizing teaching and learning, not all of them agreed with their placement at the time of the interviews. There were two groups of students thinking about changing sets.

In the first group, there were students who were placed in a group that did not suit them because of a failed test. They wanted to leave the group as soon as possible because the teaching did not correspond well to their needs: *“I had such a hard time in the English class because I started with the worse set since I was stressed and failed the sorting test. Then I was bored there because I was really ahead,”* said Lucy (middle ability group, mathematics). Lucy emphasizes that she could not truly fulfil her potential and that she often found herself in the zone of boredom and wanted to get out of this situation. Tom (high ability group, mathematics) described a similar experience: *“I messed up the placement test and I knew I should have been in the first group, so I wanted to fight, and I got straight A’s in mathematics. And that’s why they transferred me to the first one. The teacher asked who wanted to be in a different group and I applied; with my results I definitely knew I should go there.”* These students were intrinsically motivated to take steps to make the transition to a higher-ability group successful. They estimated their performance quite well, and their efforts paid off as they changed groups. In the case of Tom, the transition was additionally supported by a teacher who was interested in identifying which students were dissatisfied with their current placement in the group.

Students in the second group considered the transition for several weeks. They believed that their initial placement in the group was relevant and corresponded to their performance at the time. During the new school year, they found that they could handle the demands of a higher-ability group. Three facts led them to this realization: first, the slower-than-expected pace of teaching and learning in the current group did not fit their needs; second, experiences with teaching and learning in a joined class, in which a middle set and high-ability set worked together in the same class because of the teacher’s absence; and third, the teaching style of a teacher from the higher-ability set.

The slower pace of teaching and learning in the current group meant that some students had their assigned work completed earlier than their classmates: *“In English...I would like to go to a higher group, because I think that I am a little ahead of the others, because we are actually doing something and I have already finished it,”* said Yva (middle ability group, mathematics). A similar experience was described by the student Timi (high ability group, ESL), who pointed out that the time she had to spend waiting for other students to complete the task was not used efficiently: *“Actually, I feel that I can do more than like this... in fact, I already understand and I have to wait maybe three more days before the others*

understand and I would simply like to take another topic." While students wait for their classmates to complete the task, they either do nothing or work on other assigned tasks. However, these situations occur relatively often, and the assigned tasks for filling up the time are not sufficiently stimulating. If students repeatedly have to deal with topics they have already understood well enough, they lose the opportunity to fulfil their potential. Moreover, they were aware of this fact and openly spoke about it.

Thoughts about changing to another set were stimulated by the experience of the combined lesson. If students from a lower-ability group worked together with students from a higher-ability group during the classes taught by that group's teacher, the teaching style of the higher-ability group teacher corresponded more to the higher-ability group teaching. This means that students who belong to the lower-ability set can form at least a rough idea of what the teaching in the other group looks like. Susan (low ability group, mathematics), for example, said: *"I quite enjoy it sometimes, just like today or the other day when we were joined... I put up my hand because I knew (how to solve the assignment) and a girl who was from the best set had it completely wrong and then I tried and even though I'm in the worst group I had it right."* A positive experience from such a lesson can motivate students to intensify their efforts to change groups. In essence, thanks to these lessons, and thus by chance, students can find out what teaching in other groups can look like. Ideally, there should not have been combined classes because of the absence of a teacher at all; however, this unsystematic "trial" can lead to a rather fundamental decision to change groups. The question is whether students' performance has really improved during the school year (and, if so, what the reason for this improvement is), or whether their performance has not changed and was specified more precisely by their accomplishments during the term or just perceived as better by students themselves. According to the students, however, teachers notice changes in students' performances only with a delay; some students even claim that they are not aware of them at all, as Linda (middle ability group, mathematics) said: *"(...) before the teacher was able to realize that I did not belong to that group, half a year had already passed, so now I am already in the better group."*

The third kind of impulse that inspired the idea of changing sets is different teaching methods that students admire: *"I would like to be in the group of Mr. Novak. We were in his group when Mrs. Cerna was not at school, and we had a really great time there. They were a long way ahead and I learned some pronunciation,"* said Michael (high ability group, mathematics). Students got to know teachers from other groups in combined classes or from conversations between students. They appreciated the brisker pace in the higher-ability sets and they thought they would be able to handle it. They also valued individual characteristics of teachers, e.g. possessing good pronunciation in the English language and the ability to transfer this skill to students. While a brisker pace of learning was a characteristic of a high-ability set, excellent pronunciation is not necessarily connected exclusively to teachers from high-ability sets. The fact that students attribute the skill of excellent pronunciation to teachers from high-ability sets may be the result of the fact that the teacher with excellent pronunciation taught in the high-ability set and therefore students associated excellent pronunciation with high-ability sets even if a teacher from a low-ability set could also possess this skill.

Students who wanted to transfer soon after finding out the unsatisfactory result of the placement test had only positive expectations of being allocated to a high-ability group. On the other hand, students who had been considering the transition for several weeks had ambivalent expectations about transferring to a new group. They thought not only about what they would gain if they changed sets but also what they would lose. A faster pace of learning and appropriate teacher practices – these are the resonating promises of learning in a high-ability group. On the contrary, stepping out of the comfort zone (Moeltzen, in Smith, 2006, p. 51) and the loss of status are among the concerns mentioned by the students in connection with the transfer to a higher-ability set. Susan (low ability group, mathematics) expresses these concerns: *"Well, I was*

afraid that I would simply be a little bit behind [in the higher-ability set]. In my opinion, it's better to stay in the lower-ability group than to be somewhere where you can't handle the subject matter, right, and you don't quite keep up, so I think it's better to stay in the group where the subject matter seems to suit you, that pace and so on, rather than being in a better group, but it's as if you don't quite get it the first time and maybe they write a test and now you don't quite understand it yet, so..." In the background is the well-known phenomenon of the so-called big-fish-little-pond effect (Marsh, 1987). The student excels in their performance in the reference group, because they do not have the opportunity to compare themselves with anyone who has a higher performance. However, the student assumes that the demands in the new, high-ability group will be higher, which may lead to the loss of the status of an excellent student in the low-ability group. If the effort to change the group lies only on students and the teachers do not support them, they will probably never change group because their fears will be so strong that they will give up.

3.3. Barriers to changing set – non-transparent rules and long waiting periods

In the interviews, the students mentioned several barriers that complicate their transition. Let us look at those that resonated most strongly across conversations. Students commented on the unclear conditions they had to fulfil to change groups. They differed in their opinions, especially on who initiates the transition to another set, whether it is the teacher's responsibility or whether the students themselves can seek a change of group. Different opinions also appeared regarding whether re-taking the sorting test is necessary for the transition or other variables enter the decision-making process (e.g. activity in class).

In addition, the rules for changing groups differed across subjects. In EFL, a placement test is necessary for transition. Everyone writes the re-test in the middle of the school year. On the basis of the student's results, the teacher and the student discuss a possible change of group. Reassignment to a more suitable group could happen thanks to diligence and activity in class: *"Well, I think maybe it's just the tests, but if we said that we think we belong to a higher-ability set and we really try, then maybe they would even reassign us,"* thought Tonda (low-ability group, ESL). All the students agreed that tests are necessary to transfer to a higher-ability group, while diligence and activity in class are more a matter of speculation. The quote shows considerable uncertainty; the student is thinking aloud about the possibilities rather than explicitly formulating them.

In addition to the unclear conditions that determine entry into another set, the students complained about the long waiting period before a change of set occurs. The students said that the first opportunity to change the set is in the middle of the school year: *"One friend, although she got into the high-ability set, the four, but only after half a year,"* confirmed Ronja (middle ability group, ESL). Half-yearly transfers, however, take place even when teachers or students signal adequate knowledge and skills for higher-ability sets earlier, sometimes already a matter of weeks after the initial allocation. Students have an explanation for late transitions. They state that teachers are unable to obtain evidence of learning, so transitions occur later than students themselves would like. Dina expressed herself clearly: *"It seems to me that the teachers don't seem to realize it (performance appropriate for a higher set) at all."* Even if teachers are able to find out the current performance of students, they approach them more according to expectations and the label of a specific group. The attainment students achieved at the time of being placed is not perceived as current performance, but as a constant ability, and therefore they react to the current performance of students by delaying the student's transfer.

Students mentioned that teachers do not use transitions between groups as a standard tool, at least not to such an extent that they explicitly present them to the students. It seems that the change of the group is solved "on the fly", sometimes even ex post. According to the

students, transitions were generally rare and transitions to lower-ability groups have not occurred. Students thought that teachers were not interested in transferring students to a lower level – if transitions were discussed, teachers tried to support students transferring to a higher-ability group.

4. Discussion and future directions

There is a limited body of studies on students' perception of the criteria for grouping students, the tools for (re)grouping, and the permeability of groups. In an effort to contribute to and enrich the relatively limited knowledge we decided to examine perceptions of setting criteria and the permeability of groups through students' eyes.

This study found that students generally agree with setting by attainment, they think that measuring their performance by tests is a true reflection of their abilities and effort. Not many children in the sixth grade realize that their test performance might reflect the socio-economic status of the family the student comes from, in addition to their abilities and effort. The fact that students have not yet fully realized that performance does not necessarily depend only on innate abilities and effort, but also on socio-economic status, is a potential risk to equity. Attributing success only to innate dispositions and effort significantly distorts the real setting of society by trivializing the influence of social status on the creation and perception of merit and further contributes to limiting equal access to those who do not have sufficient support for their efforts to be fully realized into results.

This aligns with Bourdieu's notion of symbolic violence (Bourdieu, 1997) where dominant social structures instill beliefs that legitimize and perpetuate inequality. By internalizing the idea that success is purely the result of ability and hard work, students from less privileged backgrounds may come to see their lower placement as a reflection of personal inadequacy rather than systemic disadvantage (Archer et al., 2018). Applying symbolic violence as a theoretical lens provides deeper insight into how ability grouping reinforces social hierarchies under the guise of meritocracy. Students' experiences demonstrate how symbolic violence operates not only through labeling and placement but also through the subtle discouragement of mobility.

Our findings, however, reveal a paradox: students broadly endorse ability grouping as meritocratic, yet their critiques of placement tests and permeability barriers underscore systemic problem: even though they accept the social norm of ability grouping, they do not accept all the processes that lead to the implementation of this norm. They may not be aware of this contradiction but it is also possible that they consider the problems they name (the method used for determining performance, misallocation, difficulties associated with changing groups) to be operationally solvable sub-difficulties, not an inherent part of the system of grouping (e.g. Francis et al., 2017b). Either way, this contradiction creates a cognitive space that allows them to adopt the role of active actors in the system and propose its improvements.

This cognitive space for critique, "a crack", could serve as a foundation for developing a more critical awareness of educational inequalities. According to Bourdieu and Passeron (1977), moments of contradiction can prompt reflexivity, allowing individuals to question dominant ideologies rather than merely internalizing them. We can see such seeds of questioning in several student statements, where students criticize the method of students placement in conversations with researchers. However, in a system that does not systematically work with student opinions, these views may be overlooked, even though many of them are relevant.

In the interviews, the students brought up several ideas on how to ensure a more accurate placement in the group: using the teacher's judgment when a student is dissatisfied with the placement and using a trial. The implementation of their proposals could reduce one of the fundamental reasons for the adverse effects of teaching in groups, identified in their summary study by Francis et al. (2017a) – incorrect placement of a pupil in a group.

Rather than viewing students solely as passive recipients of symbolic violence, we argue that they also possess agency in navigating and reshaping their educational experiences. As our findings suggest, students are not merely accepting ability grouping in an uncritical manner; instead, they engage in nuanced discussions about its mechanisms and limitations. Research on student voice and agency highlights that when students actively participate in conversations about their education, they become co-creators rather than passive consumers of schooling (Andriana & Evans, 2020; Roberts & Nash, 2006; Rudduck & Flutter, 2000). For example, in schools that institutionalize student feedback mechanisms and involve students as active respondents (Fielding, 2001), pupils have successfully advocated for more flexible grouping policies, bridging the gap between critique and structural change.

The students presented their proposals only in conversations with the researchers, meaning they shared their ideas when questioned by an independent actor. While they had their own thoughts on how the group allocation process could work, many did not communicate them to their teachers. This type of agency can be described as "tacit student agency." Students do not merely adapt to systems—they have the capacity to reimagine them. However, they share their ideas only when prompted.

Encouraging students to articulate their opinions fosters greater engagement and ownership over their learning environments, which has been shown to positively influence student-adult relationships and self-esteem (Mager & Nowak, 2012) and academic outcomes (Kahne et al., 2022). By positioning students as active agents who can question, negotiate, and even contest educational practices, we open pathways for a more participatory and equitable school culture—one where students do not simply internalize structural disadvantages but become empowered to challenge them. To fully realize this potential, schools must create formal and informal channels for student input and foster teacher-student dialogues that legitimize youth perspectives (Cook-Sather, 2006). Such practices could transform agency from individual acts of resistance into collective movements for equity, ensuring that ability grouping evolves from a tool of sorting into a dynamic process responsive to student needs.

The students' capacity for agency—evident in their critiques and proposals for reform—exists in tension with the cognitive and social-emotional barriers that complicate group transitions. While students demonstrate nuanced awareness of grouping flaws (e.g., test anxiety distorting placements) and even imagine solutions (e.g., trial periods), their ability to act on this agency is constrained by systemic and psychological factors.

If a student is placed in a group with pace and cognitive demands that they can handle well, but where the stimulation does not reach Vygotsky's "zone of proximal development" (Vygotsky, 1978), many of them tend to settle in the comfort zone of the set. When considering a change of set, students consider not only a change in the effort they will have to make, but also a change in their status – a shift from the role of "one of the best" to one of "laggard". As Dunne et al. (2011) state, the fear of losing these advantages can be so significant for students that they prefer to remain in a lower-performing set, regardless of progress.

A transfer to both a high- and a low-ability group can be perceived as problematic (Neumann, 2019). Students attributed the transfer to a higher-ability set to their efforts, which are reflected in better grades and/or behavior. However, most students were afraid of changes of set, both upwards and downwards. Like the students in our study, they feared increased demands when moving up and a decline in status when moving down. They fear moving down significantly more than they aspire to move to a higher-performance group. They also mentioned the social ties that keep them in the current group. Concerns about transfers could also be caused by relatively significant transfers of pupils between groups. The author concludes that, from a certain perspective, the desirable higher frequency has created a competitive environment maintained by pupils' aspirations to move up and fears about moving down.

We do not attribute the motivation to stay in the current group to the

fact that students do not want to step out of their comfort zone; on the contrary, they want to, but their longer stay in a lower-performing group can affect their self-confidence and belief in their own abilities (McGillicuddy & Devine, 2018). As a result of low self-esteem and underestimation of their capabilities, students prefer to stay in a lower-performing set and avoid the perceived risks of transitioning to a higher group. This behavior mirrors findings in studies on risk aversion in educational settings, where systemic structures (e.g., high-stakes testing) amplify students' fear of failure (Hartlaub & Schneider, 2012). Socioeconomic background plays a crucial role in how risk aversion affects educational decisions. Students from higher social classes are less influenced by individual risk aversion and school performance when making educational choices, while those from lower social classes are more sensitive to these factors (Breen et al., 2014).

5. Conclusion

In the present study, we investigated how learners think about the mechanisms of ability grouping, how they approach the criteria by which they divide themselves into groups, and how they perceive the possibilities of moving between groups. We have shown that students are able to convincingly point out bottlenecks in the issue of grouping and regrouping students. They have unique insights into their learning experiences, and their active involvement could lead to more effective and equitable educational practices. Therefore, enhancing the transparency of grouping criteria and creating mechanisms for regular feedback and student agency could mitigate some of the issues inherent in ability grouping, ultimately fostering a more inclusive and supportive educational environment.

Thus, we believe that students should be active agents rather than passive consumers in their education; they can express their opinions, feelings, and attitudes about school issues with the expectation that they will be listened to (Andriana & Evans 2020; Roberts & Nash, 2006; Rudduck & Flutter, 2000). Students' active involvement not only in the learning process but also in the educational setting influences their achievement and leads to improvements in other areas of student development (Mager & Nowak, 2012).

While between-class ability grouping was introduced by schools as an alternative to selective multiyear gymnasias that are forms of traditional tracking, it is crucial to acknowledge that this method may still perpetuate some of the same issues, particularly for students placed in lower-ability groups. Our findings suggest that despite the intention to create more tailored learning environments, some students feel constrained by their group placement, leading to disengagement or dissatisfaction and might suffer from a lack of challenge or motivation, echoing the drawbacks associated with tracking systems.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the writing process

During the preparation of this work, the authors used ChatGPT (OpenAI) to improve the readability and language of the manuscript. After using this tool, the authors carefully reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the publication.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Jaroslava Simonová: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Supervision, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Jana Navrátilová:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

None.

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